

Warrior of Breathing (Stabby's Path)

A homebrew monk subclass taken at level 7 in place of Kensei. A Warrior of Breathing kindles an inner style, a visible breath that wreathes the blade. Three doors, three breathing styles; every road grants the **Nichirin Katana**, and every First Form replaces Flurry of Blows. The full text of all three follows.

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ What a Breathing Style Is

The mountain monks say a breathing style is not a trick of the lungs but a way of remembering. Every warrior carries a wild thing, a still river, and a patch of honest dark somewhere inside them; a breathing style is simply the practice of calling one of them up on purpose, and setting it down again when the fight is done. The breath, the old masters warn, is easy to light and hard to quench, which is why they teach the quenching first.

Beast Breathing: the Bloodfang Form

“You think too much, little storm. The beast does not think. The beast moves, and the beast is already behind you.” (the lesson Stabby finally understood)

Some warriors learn to still the storm inside them. The Warrior of Beast Breathing learns to ride it. Where other monks seek calm, this form reaches into the wild, animal heart of the fighter: the part that does not hesitate, does not flinch, and does not stop. Practitioners breathe in time with a racing heartbeat rather than a slow one, and when they ignite their breath, their blade glows blood-red and their body moves with the loping, unstoppable grace of a hunting beast.

It is a form born of survival rather than discipline, favored by those who grew up where the strong eat and the slow are eaten. To master it is not to tame the beast, but to become it on command, and to remember how to set it down again afterward.



Features by Monk Level. You gain Warrior of Beast Breathing features at Monk levels 3 (Beast Breathing), 6 (First Form: Devour), 11 (Advanced Beast Breathing), and 17 (Third Form: Apex Predator).

Level 3: Beast Breathing

Monk Weapons. A katana, as well as any sword you adopt as your signature blade, counts as a Monk weapon for you. You can use your Martial Arts die with it, and you can use this subclass's features with it. You can still make an Unarmed Strike as a Bonus Action.

Beast Sense. Your senses are sharp as a hunting animal's, even out of combat. You have Advantage on Wisdom (Survival) checks made to track creatures, on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on smell or hearing, and on Charisma (Intimidation) checks.

Igniting the Breath. When you roll Initiative, you can expend 1 Focus Point to ignite your breath. It lasts until the combat ends, until you have the Incapacitated condition, or until you end it (no action required).

While your breath is ignited, your weapon glows blood-red, and whenever you hit a target with it, the target takes an extra 2 Force damage.

Beast's Vigor. While your breath is ignited, your Speed increases by 10 feet, and you have Advantage on Dexterity saving throws.

Level 6: First Form: Devour

First Form: Devour. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 1 Focus Point to move up to 15 feet without provoking Opportunity Attacks and make one attack with your Monk weapon. On a hit, the target takes Force damage equal to 3d8 plus your Dexterity modifier instead of the weapon's normal damage. Bonuses to the weapon's damage rolls (such as the Nichirin katana's +2 bonus and the extra damage from your ignited breath) apply as normal. If the attack reduces the target to 0 Hit Points, you regain the expended Focus Point. This feature replaces Flurry of Blows for you.

Level 11: Advanced Beast Breathing

Advanced Breathing. Your ignited breath grows fiercer. While your breath is ignited, you retain all its other benefits, you have Resistance to Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Slashing damage, and the extra Force damage your weapon deals increases from 2 to 3.

Sharpened Fang. The damage of your First Form: Devour increases to 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier.

Level 17: Third Form: Apex Predator

Third Form: Apex Predator. You become a blur of fang and steel. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 3 Focus Points to move up to your Speed without provoking Opportunity Attacks and make one attack with your Monk weapon against each of up to three different creatures you move within reach of. On a hit, the target takes Force damage equal to 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier instead of the weapon's normal damage. Bonuses to the weapon's damage rolls (such as the Nichirin katana's +2 bonus and the extra damage from your ignited breath) apply as normal. Each creature hit must succeed on a Strength saving throw (DC 8 plus your Wisdom modifier and Proficiency Bonus) or have the Prone condition. You regain 1 expended Focus Point for each creature this feature reduces to 0 Hit Points.

Water Breathing: the Monastery Form

"Be water. Water does not strike; it flows, and the rock is cut all the same. Now breathe, and begin again." (Master Kaelon Windstep)

The Warrior of Water Breathing is the form of the patient master, the discipline that other monks spend their whole lives chasing. Its practitioners learn to move like a river: never rigid, never still, every strike flowing into the next, every blow turned aside by giving way rather than resisting. When they ignite their breath, their blade runs pale blue and cold, and their guard becomes as fluid and unbroken as a current that cannot be grasped.

It is the most traditional of the breathing forms, and the hardest to truly master, for it asks the warrior to be calm in the middle of chaos. Those who walk this path are as often menders as fighters, for the same stillness that turns a blade can also close a wound, and the same patience that wins a duel can sit a long vigil at a friend's side.



Features by Monk Level. You gain Warrior of Water Breathing features at Monk levels 3 (Water Breathing), 6 (First Form: Flowing Strike and Healing Spring, First Water), 11 (Advanced Water Breathing and the full Healing Spring), and 17 (Third Form: Tidal Crash).

Level 3: Water Breathing

Monk Weapons. A katana, as well as any sword you adopt as your signature blade, counts as a Monk weapon for you. You can use your Martial Arts die with it, and you can use this subclass's features with it. You can still make an Unarmed Strike as a Bonus Action.

Igniting the Breath. When you roll Initiative, you can expend 1 Focus Point to ignite your breath. It lasts until the combat ends, until you have the Incapacitated condition, or until you end it (no action required). While your breath is ignited, your weapon glows pale blue, and whenever you hit a target with it, the target takes an extra 2 Cold damage.

Flowing Guard. While your breath is ignited, you gain a +2 bonus to Armor Class against the first attack roll made against you before the start of each of your turns.

Level 6: First Form: Flowing Strike

First Form: Flowing Strike. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 1 Focus Point to move up to 15 feet without provoking Opportunity Attacks and make one attack with your Monk weapon. On a hit, the target takes Cold damage equal to 3d8 plus your Dexterity modifier instead of the weapon's normal damage. Bonuses to the weapon's damage rolls (such as the Nichirin katana's +2 bonus and the extra damage from your ignited breath) apply as normal. If the attack hits, the target must also succeed on a Dexterity saving throw (DC 8 plus your Wisdom modifier and Proficiency Bonus) or have the Prone condition. This feature replaces Flurry of Blows for you.

Healing Spring (First Water). As a Bonus Action, you can touch yourself or another creature, and the target regains a number of Hit Points equal to 2d8 plus your Wisdom modifier. Once you use this benefit, you can't use it again until you finish a Short or Long Rest. This benefit improves when you reach Monk level 11 (Healing Spring).

Level 11: Advanced Water Breathing

Advanced Breathing. Your ignited breath deepens. While your breath is ignited, you retain all its other benefits, and whenever you hit a creature with your Monk weapon, that creature's Speed is reduced by 10 feet until the start of your next turn.

Sharpened Flow. The damage of your First Form: Flowing Strike increases to 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier.

Healing Spring. When you use your Healing Spring, the target now regains a number of Hit Points equal to 4d8 plus your Wisdom modifier. Once you use this benefit, you can't use it again until you finish a Short or Long Rest.

Level 17: Third Form: Tidal Crash

Third Form: Tidal Crash. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 3 Focus Points to move up to 20 feet and make one attack with your Monk weapon against each of up to three different creatures within your reach during that movement. On a hit, the target takes Cold damage equal to 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier instead of the weapon's normal damage. Bonuses to the weapon's damage rolls (such as the Nichirin katana's +2 bonus and the extra damage from your ignited breath) apply as normal. Each creature hit must succeed on a Dexterity saving throw (DC 8 plus your Wisdom modifier and Proficiency Bonus) or have the Prone condition and a Speed of 0 until the end of its next turn.

Shadow Breathing: the Idol Form

"Do not fear the dark. Breathe it in. Let it fill you, and then there is nothing left in the dark to fear you." (a whisper from the idol)

The Warrior of Shadow Breathing is the strangest and most secretive of the forms, a discipline touched by something older than any monastery. Its practitioners breathe in the gloom itself, drawing the dark into their lungs until it answers to them. When they ignite their breath, their blade runs violet-black, the shadows fold around them like a cloak, and they see clearly in darkness that blinds everyone else.

Few teach this form openly, for it walks close to powers most monks are warned away from. Those who carry it often carry a question they cannot yet answer: why the dark heeds them, where the breath truly comes from, and what waits at the end of the path they have started down. Mastered well, it makes a warrior into something the night itself seems to bend around.



Features by Monk Level. You gain Warrior of Shadow Breathing features at Monk levels 3 (Shadow Breathing), 6 (First Form: Umbral Slash), 11 (Advanced Shadow Breathing), and 17 (Third Form: Eclipse).

Level 3: Shadow Breathing

Monk Weapons. A katana, as well as any sword you adopt as your signature blade, counts as a Monk weapon for you. You can use your Martial Arts die with it, and you can use this subclass's features with it. You can still make an Unarmed Strike as a Bonus Action.

Eyes of the Idol. The idol's gift never fully leaves you. You have Darkvision with a range of 60 feet (if you already have Darkvision, its range increases by 60 feet), and you have Advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks.

Igniting the Breath. When you roll Initiative, you can expend 1 Focus Point to ignite your breath. It lasts until the combat ends, until you have the Incapacitated condition, or until you end it (no action required). While your breath is ignited, your weapon glows violet-black, and whenever you hit a target with it, the target takes an extra 2 Necrotic damage.

One With the Gloom. While your breath is ignited, you gain a +2 bonus to Armor Class against ranged attack rolls, and you can see normally in magical Darkness.

Level 6: First Form: Umbral Slash

First Form: Umbral Slash. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 1 Focus Point to teleport up to 15 feet to an unoccupied space you can see within 5 feet of a creature. Magical Darkness then fills a 10-foot Cube of your choice, which must contain that creature's space. You then make one attack with your Monk weapon against that creature, and you have Advantage on the attack roll. On a hit, the target takes Necrotic damage equal to 3d8 plus your Dexterity modifier instead of the weapon's normal damage. Bonuses to the weapon's damage rolls (such as the Nichirin katana's +2 bonus and the extra damage from your ignited breath) apply as normal.

You can see through Darkness created by this feature. The Darkness lasts until the end of your next turn, or you can end it early (no action required). This feature replaces Flurry of Blows for you.

Level 11: Advanced Shadow Breathing

Advanced Breathing. Your ignited breath drinks deeper of the dark. While your breath is ignited, you retain all its other benefits. In addition, once per turn when you hit a creature with an attack roll that had Advantage, the target takes an extra 2d6 Necrotic damage.

Sharpened Gloom. The damage of your First Form: Umbral Slash increases to 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier.

Level 17: Third Form: Eclipse

Third Form: Eclipse. You vanish into the gloom and strike from everywhere at once. As a Bonus Action, you can expend 3 Focus Points to fill a 20-foot Cube centered on yourself with magical Darkness, which you can see through. For each of up to three different creatures in the Cube, you can teleport to an unoccupied space you can see within 5 feet of that creature and make one attack with your Monk weapon against it, and you have Advantage on each attack roll. On a hit, the target takes Necrotic damage equal to 5d10 plus your Dexterity modifier instead of the weapon's normal damage. Bonuses to the weapon's damage rolls (such as the Nichirin katana's +2 bonus and the extra damage from your ignited breath) apply as normal. Each creature hit has the Blinded condition until the end of your next turn, and creatures other than you can't see you until the Darkness ends.

The Demon-Slayer's Blade: the Nichirin Katana

This sun-forged demon-slayer blade was made from crimson ore that drinks in dawnlight. While sheathed, the steel looks dark and almost ordinary, but when Stabby ignites his breathing, the blade catches that breath and burns with the color of his chosen form.

Nichirin Katana

Weapon (Katana), Rare (Requires Attunement by Stabby)

Weapon Statistics. The Nichirin katana uses the statistics of a Longsword (1d8 Slashing damage) and has the Finesse and Versatile (1d10) properties, and it counts as a Monk weapon for you. Because the weapon has the Finesse property and is a Monk weapon for you, you can use your Dexterity modifier for its attack and damage rolls.

Magic Weapon. You gain a +2 bonus to attack rolls and damage rolls made with this magic weapon.

Breath-Kindled Steel. When you ignite your breathing, the blade glows with the color and nature of that form: blood-red for Beast Breathing, pale blue for Water Breathing, or violet-black for Shadow Breathing. This glow is magical but sheds only Dim Light unless you choose otherwise.

Cleansing Edge. Once per turn when you hit a Fiend, an Undead, a shadow creature, or a creature empowered by planar corruption with this weapon, the blade burns away corruption until the start of your next turn. Until then, the target can't regain Hit Points and can't benefit from magical Darkness or shadowy concealment against you. Any visible corruption around the wound briefly burns, cracks, or peels away in sparks of purified light.

The blade wounds the corruption, not the creature beneath; when a corrupted guardian falls to it, what breaks is the darkness.



The Nichirin Katana: dark steel waiting for dawnlight.

Lore of the Blade

They say the first Nichirin blades were quenched not in water or oil but in the light of dawn itself, folded by smiths who worked only in the hour before sunrise. The ore came from a single mountain that caught the morning sun before anywhere else in the world, and steel drawn from it never forgot that first warmth. A finished blade looks plain and dark in an idle hand; it is waiting. Only a warrior who can kindle their own breath can wake the color sleeping in the metal.

For a creature of corruption, that waking light is a death sentence. Where an ordinary sword cuts flesh, a Nichirin blade cuts the rot itself: the shadow that hides a fiend, the dark magic that knits an undead back together, the planar taint that lets a horror shrug off honest steel. Stabby's blade chose its colors from his own breathing forms, and now it burns red, blue, or violet to match whichever beast, river, or shadow he calls upon.

A whispered rumor. Old hunters claim a Nichirin blade can never be truly stolen: carried by the wrong hand, the steel stays cold and dull and will not take an edge. No one in living memory has dared find out.

Setting Down the Kensei's Way

When Stabby takes up a breathing form at Level 7, the Kensei's tricks retire with his old teacher's lessons: Kensei's Shot and Agile Parry go, and the Repeating Longbow becomes simply a very good bow. In exchange he gains a stance he can ignite every single fight, a First Form that turns his Bonus Action into a $3d8 + 5$ strike with 15 feet of free movement, and a road that grows with him to Level 17. He is trading a parry for a predator's gait. (And Candyfang remains: an heirloom at his belt, or one day a gift worthy of a Bloodfang.)